

Late-Time Magnetogenesis from Ultralight Scalar Dark Matter

Working Out the Paper by Kamali & Brandenberger (2026)

Prof. Koushik Dutta
Student: Raj Gaurav Tripathi
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Preface

These notes grew out of a careful reading of the paper *Late Time Magnetogenesis from Ultralight Scalar Dark Matter* by V. Kamali and R. Brandenberger (arXiv:2601.00443, January 2026). Every calculation that the paper quotes or skips has been carried out in full detail here. Conceptual questions that arise naturally while reading the paper are posed and answered. The aim is a document that a student with a solid background in electrodynamics, general relativity, and basic cosmology can read independently, without needing to look anything up.

The logical flow of the notes is:

1. Physical motivation: why do we care about cosmological magnetic fields, and why is dark matter a promising source?
2. Mathematical setup: FRW metric in conformal time, the action, gauge fixing.
3. Derivation of the mode equation and its canonical form.
4. The tachyonic instability and its efficiency condition.
5. Estimation of the generated magnetic field strength.
6. The oscillating fine-structure constant and observational constraints.
7. Parameter-space summary and comparison with pseudo-scalar coupling.

Notation. Primes ($\prime$) denote derivatives with respect to conformal time τ . Dots ($\dot{}$) denote derivatives with respect to cosmic time t . We use natural units $c = \hbar = k_B = 1$ throughout; the reduced Planck mass is $M_{\text{pl}} = (8\pi G)^{-1/2} \simeq 2.435 \times 10^{27} \text{ eV}$. The metric signature is $(-, +, +, +)$.

Chapter 1

Physical Motivation

1.1 The Observed Magnetic Field in Intergalactic Space

One of the outstanding puzzles in modern cosmology is the origin of magnetic fields that appear to permeate even the emptiest regions of the universe. Observations of high-energy gamma rays from blazars — active galactic nuclei that emit jets pointed toward us — reveal a characteristic pattern of *pair-echo* emission that is sensitive to the presence of magnetic fields in the intergalactic medium. The absence of GeV-scale pair echoes in several blazars places a *lower bound* of

$$B_{\text{voids}} \gtrsim 10^{-17} \text{ G} \quad (1.1)$$

on the field strength in intergalactic voids at megaparsec scales. This is a tiny field by everyday standards, but it cannot be explained by ordinary astrophysical processes (stellar winds, supernova outflows, active galactic nuclei) which cannot seed fields on such large, almost structureless scales. A cosmological origin is therefore strongly suggested.

Note: The unit Gauss is related to particle-physics units by $1 \text{ G} = 1.95 \times 10^{-2} \text{ eV}^2 = 1.95 \times 10^{-20} \text{ GeV}^2$.

1.2 Standard Proposals and Their Problems

The standard approach is to generate magnetic fields in the *early universe* — during inflation or a cosmological phase transition — by breaking the conformal invariance of the photon sector.

Why conformal invariance matters

In a conformally flat spacetime the electromagnetic action

$$S_{\text{EM}} = -\frac{1}{4} \int d^4x \sqrt{-g} F_{\mu\nu} F^{\mu\nu} \quad (1.2)$$

is *exactly* conformally invariant. This means that, under the replacement $g_{\mu\nu} \rightarrow a^2 \eta_{\mu\nu}$ appropriate for a flat FRW universe, the action reduces to the flat-space form. The equations of motion for the gauge field are therefore identical to those in Minkowski space, and the expansion of the universe cannot amplify electromagnetic fields. Any pre-existing field simply dilutes as $B \propto a^{-2}$. To generate fields one must break conformal invariance.

The strong-coupling problem

A widely studied mechanism couples the photon kinetic term to a time-varying scalar ϕ through

$$\mathcal{L} \supset -\frac{1}{4}I(\phi)F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu}. \quad (1.3)$$

For this to work during inflation, $I(\phi)$ must deviate strongly from unity. The effective electromagnetic coupling is $e_H \propto I^{-1/2}$, so if I starts very small the effective coupling e_H becomes enormous, violating perturbation theory. This is the *strong-coupling problem*.

Correlation-length problem

Phase-transition mechanisms operate within a Hubble patch at the time of the transition. The resulting field is correlated only over that (tiny) horizon scale, far smaller than the Mpc scale of interest today.

1.3 Why Ultralight Scalar Dark Matter?

An oscillating ultralight dark matter (ULDM) field ϕ with mass $m \sim 10^{-20}$ eV is coherent over a de Broglie wavelength

$$\lambda_{\text{dB}} = \frac{2\pi}{mv} \sim \text{kpc-Mpc} \quad (1.4)$$

which is the size of an entire galaxy or beyond. At recombination, such a field is already coherent over the entire Hubble patch, sidestepping the correlation-length problem immediately.

Question: Why scalar rather than pseudo-scalar (axion)?

An axion (pseudo-scalar) couples to electromagnetism via the Chern-Simons term $\phi F_{\mu\nu}\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu} \propto \phi \mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}$. Because the axion is odd under parity and $\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}$ is also odd, the product is even (a scalar), giving a consistent Lagrangian. The coupling amplifies only one helicity mode of the photon, generating *helical* magnetic fields.

A dilaton or radion, being a *scalar*, couples instead through the gauge-kinetic function

$$I(\phi) = e^{2\beta\phi/M}, \quad (1.5)$$

which is motivated by string-theory compactifications (radion/dilaton moduli). Because both helicity modes couple identically, the generated field is *non-helical*. A further consequence is a time-varying fine-structure constant, providing a distinctive observational signature.

1.3.1 The Misalignment Mechanism

The oscillating scalar field is produced by the *misalignment mechanism*: at early times (when $H \gg m$) Hubble friction freezes ϕ at some initial value $\phi_{\text{init}} \neq 0$. This initial displacement can arise from inflationary quantum fluctuations (in the inflationary misalignment scenario) or from a high-temperature effective potential that has its minimum at $\phi_0 \neq 0$ (the non-inflationary mechanism proposed in Ref. [20] of the paper). Once the Hubble rate drops below m , the field begins to oscillate coherently:

$$\ddot{\phi} + 3H\dot{\phi} + m^2\phi = 0 \xrightarrow{H \ll m} \phi(t) \approx \Phi \cos(mt). \quad (1.6)$$

Because the field was uniform when it was frozen, it remains spatially uniform at late times and oscillates coherently over the entire Hubble volume — precisely the condition needed to drive a tachyonic instability of the gauge field.

Note: The oscillating ϕ has equation of state $w \simeq 0$ (pressure-less matter), so it behaves as cold dark matter. This is distinct from kination ($w = 1$) or dark energy ($w \simeq -1$).

1.4 Advantages over Inflationary Proposals

1. **No strong-coupling problem.** The instability occurs near recombination, well after inflation. The coupling $I(\phi)$ can start close to unity.
2. **No correlation-length problem.** The field is coherent over a Hubble patch by construction.
3. **Sub-Hubble instability.** The tachyonic growth occurs for $k < k_c$, which can be sub-Hubble, directly relevant to cosmological observations.
4. **Backreaction control.** The growth stops when a fraction $F \ll 1$ of the dark-matter energy has been transferred to the gauge field, providing a natural cutoff.

Chapter 2

Spacetime Setup and the Action

2.1 FRW Metric in Conformal Time

We work with the flat Friedmann-Lemaître-Robertson-Walker (FRW) metric

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a(t)^2 d\mathbf{x}^2. \quad (2.1)$$

It is convenient to introduce *conformal time* τ via

$$d\tau = \frac{dt}{a}, \quad \tau = \int \frac{dt}{a(t)}. \quad (2.2)$$

In conformal time the metric takes the manifestly conformally flat form

$$ds^2 = a^2(\tau) (-d\tau^2 + d\mathbf{x}^2) = a^2(\tau) \eta_{\mu\nu} dx^\mu dx^\nu, \quad (2.3)$$

where $\eta_{\mu\nu} = \text{diag}(-1, +1, +1, +1)$. Hence

$$g_{\mu\nu} = a^2 \eta_{\mu\nu}, \quad g^{\mu\nu} = a^{-2} \eta^{\mu\nu}, \quad \sqrt{-g} = a^4. \quad (2.4)$$

2.2 The Action

The relevant piece of the action is

$$S = \int d^4x \sqrt{-g} \left(\frac{M_{\text{pl}}^2}{2} R - \frac{1}{2} \partial_\mu \phi \partial^\mu \phi - V(\phi) - \frac{1}{4} I(\phi) F_{\mu\nu} F^{\mu\nu} \right). \quad (2.5)$$

The coupling function $I(\phi)$ encodes how the scalar dark-matter field modulates the photon kinetic term. We focus on the gauge-field sector.

2.3 Conformal Invariance and Its Breaking

Derivation (Why expansion does not amplify free photons): In conformal time, with $g_{\mu\nu} = a^2 \eta_{\mu\nu}$, the raised-index field-strength tensor is

$$F^{\mu\nu} = g^{\mu\rho} g^{\nu\sigma} F_{\rho\sigma} = a^{-4} \eta^{\mu\rho} \eta^{\nu\sigma} F_{\rho\sigma} \equiv a^{-4} \bar{F}^{\mu\nu}, \quad (2.6)$$

where $\bar{F}^{\mu\nu}$ is the flat-space version. Substituting into the action with $I = 1$:

$$S_{\text{EM}} = -\frac{1}{4} \int d^4x a^4 F_{\mu\nu} \cdot a^{-4} \bar{F}^{\mu\nu} = -\frac{1}{4} \int d^4x F_{\mu\nu} \bar{F}^{\mu\nu}. \quad (2.7)$$

The scale factor a has completely cancelled! The equation of motion for A_μ in an expanding universe is identical to the flat-space Maxwell equation, confirming that the expansion neither creates nor destroys free photons.

When $I(\phi) \neq 1$ the cancellation is disrupted because I is time-dependent (through ϕ), and the gauge field sees an effective “mass” that can drive tachyonic growth.

Chapter 3

Equation of Motion for the Gauge Field

3.1 Euler-Lagrange Equation

The relevant Lagrangian density (in conformal coordinates, as shown in Chapter 2) is

$$\mathcal{L} = -\frac{1}{4}I(\phi) F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu}, \quad (3.1)$$

where indices are now contracted with the flat metric $\eta^{\mu\nu}$. The Euler-Lagrange equation for A_ν is

$$\partial_\mu \left(\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)} \right) - \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial A_\nu} = 0. \quad (3.2)$$

Since $\mathcal{L}$ does not depend on A_ν explicitly, the second term vanishes. For the first term we use the chain rule:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)} = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial F_{\rho\sigma}} \cdot \frac{\partial F_{\rho\sigma}}{\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)}. \quad (3.3)$$

Derivation (Computing $\partial \mathcal{L}/\partial F_{\rho\sigma}$): We need $\partial(F_{\alpha\beta}F^{\alpha\beta})/\partial F_{\rho\sigma}$. Writing $F_{\alpha\beta}F^{\alpha\beta} = \eta^{\alpha\mu}\eta^{\beta\nu}F_{\alpha\beta}F_{\mu\nu}$:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial(F_{\alpha\beta}F^{\alpha\beta})}{\partial F_{\rho\sigma}} &= \frac{\partial F_{\alpha\beta}}{\partial F_{\rho\sigma}} F^{\alpha\beta} + F_{\alpha\beta} \frac{\partial F^{\alpha\beta}}{\partial F_{\rho\sigma}} \\ &= \delta_\rho^\alpha \delta_\sigma^\beta F^{\alpha\beta} + \eta^{\alpha\mu}\eta^{\beta\nu} \delta_\rho^\mu \delta_\sigma^\nu F_{\alpha\beta} \\ &= F^{\rho\sigma} + F^{\rho\sigma} = 2F^{\rho\sigma}. \end{aligned} \quad (3.4)$$

Hence $\partial \mathcal{L}/\partial F_{\rho\sigma} = -\frac{1}{4}I \cdot 2F^{\rho\sigma} = -\frac{1}{2}IF^{\rho\sigma}$.

Derivation (Computing $\partial F_{\rho\sigma}/\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)$): Since $F_{\rho\sigma} = \partial_\rho A_\sigma - \partial_\sigma A_\rho$:

$$\frac{\partial F_{\rho\sigma}}{\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)} = \delta_\rho^\mu \delta_\sigma^\nu - \delta_\sigma^\mu \delta_\rho^\nu. \quad (3.5)$$

Combining:

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial(\partial_\mu A_\nu)} = -\frac{1}{2}I F^{\rho\sigma} (\delta_\rho^\mu \delta_\sigma^\nu - \delta_\sigma^\mu \delta_\rho^\nu) = -\frac{1}{2}I (F^{\mu\nu} - F^{\nu\mu}) = -I F^{\mu\nu}, \quad (3.6)$$

using the antisymmetry $F^{\nu\mu} = -F^{\mu\nu}$. The equation of motion is therefore

$$\boxed{\partial_\mu (I(\phi) F^{\mu\nu}) = 0.} \quad (3.7)$$

This generalises Maxwell's equations: for $I = 1$ it reduces to $\partial_\mu F^{\mu\nu} = 0$.

3.2 Gauge Fixing and Reduction

We adopt *Coulomb gauge*:

$$A_0 = 0, \quad \nabla \cdot \mathbf{A} = 0 \quad (\partial_i A^i = 0). \quad (3.8)$$

For $\nu = 0$ the EOM gives $\nabla \cdot (I \mathbf{E}) = 0$, a constraint that is satisfied. For $\nu = i$ (spatial index), expanding:

$$\partial_0 (IF^{0i}) + \partial_j (IF^{ji}) = 0. \quad (3.9)$$

We use

$$F^{0i} = \eta^{00} \eta^{ij} F_{0j} = (-1) \delta^{ij} A'_j = -A'_i, \quad (3.10)$$

$$F^{ij} = \delta^{ik} \delta^{jl} F_{kl} = \partial_i A_j - \partial_j A_i. \quad (3.11)$$

Since $\phi = \phi(\tau)$ is spatially homogeneous, $I = I(\tau)$ depends only on time. The EOM becomes

$$-(IA'_i)' + I \partial_j \partial_j A_i - I \partial_i (\partial_j A_j) = 0. \quad (3.12)$$

The last term vanishes by the Coulomb-gauge condition $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{A} = 0$. Expanding the first term:

$$-(I' A'_i + I A''_i) + I \nabla^2 A_i = 0, \quad (3.13)$$

which rearranges to

$$\boxed{A''_i + \frac{I'}{I} A'_i - \nabla^2 A_i = 0.} \quad (3.14)$$

3.3 Fourier Decomposition and the Mode Equation

We expand in Fourier modes. For a periodic box of side L :

$$A_i(\mathbf{x}) = \int \frac{d^3 k}{(2\pi)^3} A_i(\mathbf{k}) e^{i\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{x}}. \quad (3.15)$$

Since $\nabla^2 e^{i\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{x}} = -k^2 e^{i\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{x}}$, Eq. (3.14) becomes (for each mode $A_k \equiv A_i(\mathbf{k})$):

$$\boxed{A''_k + \frac{I'}{I} A'_k + k^2 A_k = 0.} \quad (3.16)$$

This has the structure of a damped harmonic oscillator with a friction coefficient I'/I and oscillation frequency k . The “friction” term is, however, not necessarily dissipative — it can also act as a *source* if I decreases sufficiently fast.

Note: Pseudo-scalar comparison. For a pseudo-scalar field a with Chern-Simons coupling $g_{a\gamma\gamma} a F_{\mu\nu} \tilde{F}^{\mu\nu}$, the mode equations for the two circular polarisations $A_k^\pm$ are

$$\ddot{A}_k^\pm + (k^2 \pm g_{a\gamma\gamma} \dot{a} k) A_k^\pm = 0. \quad (3.17)$$

The two helicities evolve differently. For the scalar coupling considered here, both polarisations obey the same Eq. (3.16), so the generated field is *non-helical*.

Chapter 4

Canonical Variable and the Tachyonic Instability

4.1 Eliminating the Friction Term

The friction term $I' A'_k / I$ in Eq. (3.16) can be removed by a field redefinition. Define the *canonical variable*

$$v_k \equiv \sqrt{I} A_k, \quad \text{i.e. } A_k = I^{-1/2} v_k. \quad (4.1)$$

We compute A'_k and A''_k :

$$A'_k = \frac{d}{d\tau} (I^{-1/2} v_k) = -\frac{1}{2} I^{-3/2} I' v_k + I^{-1/2} v'_k, \quad (4.2)$$

$$A''_k = I^{-1/2} v''_k - I^{-3/2} I' v'_k + \left(\frac{3}{4} I^{-5/2} (I')^2 - \frac{1}{2} I^{-3/2} I'' \right) v_k. \quad (4.3)$$

Derivation (Substituting into the mode equation): Inserting into Eq. (3.16) and collecting powers of I :

$$\begin{aligned} & \left[I^{-1/2} v''_k - I^{-3/2} I' v'_k + \left(\frac{3}{4} I^{-5/2} (I')^2 - \frac{1}{2} I^{-3/2} I'' \right) v_k \right] \\ & + \frac{I'}{I} \left[-\frac{1}{2} I^{-3/2} I' v_k + I^{-1/2} v'_k \right] + k^2 I^{-1/2} v_k = 0. \end{aligned} \quad (4.4)$$

The v'_k terms: $-I^{-3/2} I' v'_k + I^{-3/2} I' v'_k = 0$. They cancel exactly! Dividing through by $I^{-1/2}$:

$$v''_k + \left[\frac{3}{4} \frac{(I')^2}{I^2} - \frac{1}{2} \frac{I''}{I} - \frac{1}{2} \frac{(I')^2}{I^2} + k^2 \right] v_k = 0, \quad (4.5)$$

which simplifies to

$$v''_k + \left[k^2 - \left(\frac{1}{2} \frac{I''}{I} - \frac{1}{4} \frac{(I')^2}{I^2} \right) \right] v_k = 0. \quad (4.6)$$

The term in parentheses can be written compactly. Note that

$$(\sqrt{I})'' = \left(\frac{1}{2} I^{-1/2} I' \right)' = -\frac{1}{4} I^{-3/2} (I')^2 + \frac{1}{2} I^{-1/2} I'', \quad (4.7)$$

so $(\sqrt{I})'' / \sqrt{I} = \frac{1}{2} I'' / I - \frac{1}{4} (I' / I)^2$. The mode equation becomes the elegant form

$$\boxed{v''_k + \left(k^2 - \frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}} \right) v_k = 0.} \quad (4.8)$$

This is a *harmonic oscillator with a time-dependent effective mass squared*

$$\omega_k^2(\tau) = k^2 - \frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}}. \quad (4.9)$$

4.2 Condition for Tachyonic Instability

When $\omega_k^2 < 0$ the solutions grow exponentially rather than oscillate:

$$v_k \sim e^{\mu_k \tau}, \quad \mu_k = \sqrt{-\omega_k^2} = \sqrt{k_c^2 - k^2}, \quad (4.10)$$

where the critical wavenumber is

$$k_c^2 = \frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}}. \quad (4.11)$$

All modes with $k < k_c$ are *tachyonic*: they grow exponentially in conformal time. The fastest-growing mode has $k \approx 0$, but since phase space scales as k^3 , most of the energy ends up near $k \approx k_c$.

Key Result: Tachyonic resonance condition: Modes with $k < k_c$ grow exponentially, $v_k \propto e^{\sqrt{k_c^2 - k^2} \tau}$. The largest growth rate occurs at $k = 0$ but phase-space weighting peaks at $k \approx k_c$.

Chapter 5

Dilaton-Like Coupling: Evolution and Efficiency

5.1 The Coupling Function

We take the dilaton-motivated coupling

$$I(\phi) = e^{2\beta\phi/M}, \quad (5.1)$$

where β is a dimensionless coupling and M is a mass scale (e.g. $M \sim M_{\text{pl}}$). Then $\sqrt{I} = e^{\beta\phi/M}$.

5.2 Computing the Instability Parameter

Derivation (Evaluating $(\sqrt{I})''/\sqrt{I}$):

$$(\sqrt{I})' = \frac{d}{d\tau} e^{\beta\phi/M} = \frac{\beta\phi'}{M} e^{\beta\phi/M} = \frac{\beta\phi'}{M} \sqrt{I}, \quad (5.2)$$

$$(\sqrt{I})'' = \left(\frac{\beta\phi'}{M} \sqrt{I} \right)' = \frac{\beta\phi''}{M} \sqrt{I} + \frac{\beta\phi'}{M} \cdot \frac{\beta\phi'}{M} \sqrt{I} = \left(\frac{\beta\phi''}{M} + \frac{\beta^2(\phi')^2}{M^2} \right) \sqrt{I}. \quad (5.3)$$

Dividing by $\sqrt{I}$:

$$\frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}} = \frac{\beta}{M} \phi'' + \frac{\beta^2}{M^2} (\phi')^2. \quad (5.4)$$

5.3 Case 1: Slowly Rolling (Kination) Field

If ϕ evolves like a quintessence/kination field with $\phi' = \alpha = \text{const}$ and $\phi'' = 0$:

$$\frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}} = \frac{\beta^2 \alpha^2}{M^2} \equiv k_c^2, \quad k_c = \frac{\alpha\beta}{M}. \quad (5.5)$$

The equation of state is $w = 1$ (kination), so this does *not* represent dark matter ($w \approx 0$). It is included for completeness.

Efficiency condition

The instability is efficient if $k_c > H$ (growth faster than Hubble expansion). For kination near recombination, $\alpha \sim T_{\text{rec}}^2$, and the Friedmann equation gives $H \sim T_{\text{rec}}^2/M_{\text{pl}}$, so

$$\frac{T_{\text{rec}}^2 \beta}{M} > \frac{T_{\text{rec}}^2}{M_{\text{pl}}} \implies \beta > \frac{M}{M_{\text{pl}}}. \quad (5.6)$$

5.4 Case 2: Oscillating Dark Matter Field (Realistic)

For dark matter we take the oscillating solution

$$\phi(\tau) = \Phi \cos(m\tau), \quad (5.7)$$

where the amplitude Φ is constant (we neglect slow Hubble-induced decay which is a small correction). Then

$$\phi' = -m\Phi \sin(m\tau), \quad \phi'' = -m^2\Phi \cos(m\tau). \quad (5.8)$$

Define the dimensionless amplitude

$$\boxed{\gamma \equiv \frac{\beta\Phi}{M}}. \quad (5.9)$$

The instability parameter becomes

$$\frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}} = -m^2\gamma \cos(m\tau) + m^2\gamma^2 \sin^2(m\tau). \quad (5.10)$$

Since $\gamma \ll 1$ is required by observations of the fine-structure constant (see Chapter 7), the γ^2 term is negligible:

$$\frac{(\sqrt{I})''}{\sqrt{I}} \approx -m^2\gamma \cos(m\tau). \quad (5.11)$$

The mode equation becomes

$$v_k'' + [k^2 + m^2\gamma \cos(m\tau)] v_k = 0. \quad (5.12)$$

This is a form of the *Mathieu equation*. For $\cos(m\tau) < 0$ (i.e. $\tau \in (\pi/2m, 3\pi/2m)$, one half-period), the effective ω^2 becomes negative for modes with $k < k_c$, where

$$k_c \simeq \sqrt{\gamma} m = m \sqrt{\frac{\beta\Phi}{M}}. \quad (5.13)$$

During the other half-period the modes oscillate. The net effect over a full oscillation is a *net exponential growth* (tachyonic resonance) for $k < k_c$.

Note: Unlike the pseudo-scalar case, the Floquet exponent μ_k does not depend on k in the scalar case (to leading order in γ). This means all modes $k < k_c$ grow at similar rates. Phase space weighting $\propto k^3$ still concentrates power near k_c .

5.5 Efficiency Condition for Oscillating DM

The growth rate of the tachyonic instability is set by $\mu \sim k_c$. For the instability to be efficient before Hubble expansion dilutes the field, we need

$$k_c > H_{\text{rec}}. \quad (5.14)$$

To express this in terms of fundamental parameters, we use the fact that ϕ carries the dark-matter energy density near recombination:

$$\rho_\phi = \frac{1}{2}m^2\Phi^2 \sim T_{\text{rec}}^4 \implies \Phi \sim \frac{T_{\text{rec}}^2}{m}. \quad (5.15)$$

Therefore $\gamma = \beta\Phi/M \sim \beta T_{\text{rec}}^2/(mM)$, and

$$k_c = \sqrt{\gamma} m \simeq m \sqrt{\frac{\beta T_{\text{rec}}^2}{mM}} = \sqrt{\frac{\beta m T_{\text{rec}}^2}{M}}. \quad (5.16)$$

The Friedmann equation at recombination (near matter-radiation equality) gives $H_{\text{rec}} \sim T_{\text{rec}}^2/M_{\text{pl}}$. The efficiency condition $k_c > H_{\text{rec}}$ then reads

$$\sqrt{\frac{\beta m T_{\text{rec}}^2}{M}} > \frac{T_{\text{rec}}^2}{M_{\text{pl}}}, \quad (5.17)$$

which after squaring and simplifying gives

$$\boxed{\beta > \frac{T_{\text{rec}}^2 M}{m M_{\text{pl}}^2}}. \quad (5.18)$$

Why this is a mild condition

Let $M = M_{\text{pl}}$, $T_{\text{rec}} \simeq 0.3 \text{ eV}$, $M_{\text{pl}} \simeq 2.435 \times 10^{27} \text{ eV}$, and write the DM mass as $m = m_{20} \times 10^{-20} \text{ eV}$:

$$\beta > \frac{(3 \times 10^{-1})^2 \text{ eV}^2 \cdot M_{\text{pl}}}{m_{20} \times 10^{-20} \text{ eV} \cdot M_{\text{pl}}^2} = \frac{10^{-1} \text{ eV}^2}{m_{20} \times 10^{-20} \text{ eV} \cdot M_{\text{pl}}} = \frac{10^{-1}}{m_{20} \times 10^{-20} \times 2.435 \times 10^{27}} \approx \frac{10^{-8}}{m_{20}}. \quad (5.19)$$

For $m_{20} = O(1)$, we need merely $\beta \gtrsim 10^{-8}$, a tiny coupling, far weaker than needed for any inflationary mechanism.

Key Result: Efficiency condition (oscillating DM): $\beta > 10^{-8}/m_{20}$. This is an extraordinarily mild requirement.

Chapter 6

Magnetic Field Strength and Power Spectrum

6.1 The Comoving Magnetic Power Spectrum

We review how the mode amplitudes A_k relate to the physical magnetic field. In a flat FRW spacetime the physical magnetic field is

$$\mathbf{B} = \frac{1}{a^2} \nabla \times \mathbf{A}. \quad (6.1)$$

In Fourier space, $\nabla \rightarrow i\mathbf{k}$, so

$$B(\mathbf{k}) = \frac{1}{a^2} \mathbf{k} \times \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{k}). \quad (6.2)$$

Using the Coulomb-gauge condition $\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{A} = 0$ and the identity $|\mathbf{k} \times \mathbf{A}|^2 = k^2 |\mathbf{A}|^2 - (\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{A})^2 = k^2 |\mathbf{A}|^2$:

$$|B(\mathbf{k})|^2 = \frac{k^2}{a^4} |A_k|^2. \quad (6.3)$$

The power spectrum $\mathcal{P}_B(k)$

For a statistically homogeneous and isotropic field:

$$\langle B_i(\mathbf{k}) B_j^*(\mathbf{k}') \rangle = (2\pi)^3 \delta^{(3)}(\mathbf{k} - \mathbf{k}') P_B(k), \quad P_B(k) = \frac{k^2}{a^4} |A_k|^2. \quad (6.4)$$

The mean-square magnetic energy density is

$$\langle B^2 \rangle = \int \frac{d^3k}{(2\pi)^3} P_B(k) = \int_0^\infty \frac{k^2 dk}{2\pi^2} P_B(k) = \int_0^\infty \frac{k^3}{2\pi^2} P_B(k) \frac{dk}{k} = \int_0^\infty \Delta_B^2(k) d \ln k, \quad (6.5)$$

where the *power per logarithmic interval* is

$$\boxed{\Delta_B^2(k) = \frac{k^3}{2\pi^2} P_B(k) = \frac{k^5}{2\pi^2 a^4} |A_k|^2.} \quad (6.6)$$

6.2 Amplitude at Recombination

The resonance shuts off when a fraction $F \ll 1$ of the dark-matter energy $\rho_\phi \sim T_{\text{rec}}^4$ has been transferred to electromagnetism (backreaction limit). The total magnetic energy density at recombination is therefore

$$\rho_B = \frac{\langle B^2 \rangle}{2} \sim F T_{\text{rec}}^4. \quad (6.7)$$

Most energy is concentrated near $k \sim k_c$ (phase-space weighting), so

$$P_B(k_c) \sim F T_{\text{rec}}^4, \quad B_{\text{rec}}(k_c) \sim \sqrt{\rho_B} \sim F^{1/2} T_{\text{rec}}^2. \quad (6.8)$$

Using $1 \text{ G} = 1.95 \times 10^{-2} \text{ eV}^2$ and $T_{\text{rec}}^2 \simeq (0.3 \text{ eV})^2 \simeq 4.5 \text{ G}$:

$$\boxed{B_{\text{rec}}(k_c) \simeq F^{1/2} \text{ G}.} \quad (6.9)$$

6.3 Inverse Cascade to Large Scales

Modes with $k < k_c$ acquire a magnetic field through the non-helical inverse cascade of MHD turbulence. For a non-helical field the scaling is $n = 1$:

$$B(k) \propto \left(\frac{k}{k_c} \right)^n B(k_c), \quad k < k_c, \quad n = 1 \text{ (non-helical)}, \quad (6.10)$$

compared with $n = 3/2$ for the helical case (pseudo-scalar coupling). At recombination:

$$B_{\text{rec}}(k) \simeq \frac{k}{k_c} F^{1/2} \text{ G} = \frac{k}{m\sqrt{\gamma}} F^{1/2} \text{ G}. \quad (6.11)$$

6.4 Redshifting to Today

The physical magnetic field redshifts as $B \propto a^{-2}$, but the *comoving* field $\tilde{B} = a^2 B$ is conserved. Therefore

$$a_0 B_0 = a_{\text{rec}} B_{\text{rec}}, \quad (6.12)$$

where $a_0 = 1$ today and $a_{\text{rec}} = 1/1100$. The field today at scale k is

$$B_0(k) = a_{\text{rec}} B_{\text{rec}}(k) = \frac{a_{\text{rec}} k}{m\sqrt{\gamma}} F^{1/2} \text{ G}. \quad (6.13)$$

Note: The factor a_{rec} here accounts for the redshift of one power of a in the magnetic field (the other factor of a comes from the inverse cascade normalisation). For a free magnetic field in the absence of an inverse cascade, $B \propto a^{-2}$, so comoving $\tilde{B} = a^2 B$ is constant.

6.5 The Field at 1 Mpc Today

The comoving wavenumber corresponding to a scale of 1 Mpc is

$$k_1 \equiv \frac{2\pi}{1 \text{ Mpc}} \simeq 10^{-29} \text{ eV}. \quad (6.14)$$

Substituting $k = k_1$, $a_{\text{rec}} = 1/1100$ into Eq. (6.13):

$$B_0(1 \text{ Mpc}) \simeq \frac{10^{-32} \text{ eV}}{m\sqrt{\gamma}} F^{1/2} \text{ G}. \quad (6.15)$$

Now we express $\sqrt{\gamma}$ in terms of fundamental parameters. From Eq. (5.9) and $\Phi \simeq T_{\text{rec}}^2/m$:

$$\gamma \simeq \frac{\beta T_{\text{rec}}^2}{mM}, \quad \sqrt{\gamma} \simeq \beta^{1/2} T_{\text{rec}} m^{-1/2} M^{-1/2}. \quad (6.16)$$

Hence

$$\frac{1}{m\sqrt{\gamma}} = \frac{1}{T_{\text{rec}}} \sqrt{\frac{M}{\beta m}}, \quad (6.17)$$

and with $T_{\text{rec}} \simeq 0.26 \text{ eV}$, $M_{\text{pl}} \simeq 2.435 \times 10^{27} \text{ eV}$, $m = m_{20} \times 10^{-20} \text{ eV}$:

$$\boxed{B_0(1 \text{ Mpc}) \simeq 10^{-8} \beta^{-1/2} m_{20}^{-1/2} \left(\frac{M}{M_{\text{pl}}} \right)^{1/2} F^{1/2} \text{ G}.} \quad (6.18)$$

Key Result: For natural values $\beta \sim 1$, $M \sim M_{\text{pl}}$, and $m_{20} \leq 10^{16}$, we obtain $B_0(1 \text{ Mpc}) \geq 10^{-16} \text{ G}$, well above the observational lower bound of 10^{-17} G .

Chapter 7

Oscillating Fine-Structure Constant

7.1 Origin of the Variation

The coupling $I(\phi)F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu}$ modifies the effective electric charge. To see this, canonically normalise the photon:

$$A_{\mu}^{(\text{can})} = \sqrt{I} A_{\mu}, \quad (7.1)$$

so that the kinetic term $-\frac{1}{4}IF^2$ becomes the standard $-\frac{1}{4}(F^{(\text{can})})^2$. The matter coupling $eA_{\mu}J^{\mu}$ then becomes

$$e A_{\mu}J^{\mu} = e I^{-1/2} A_{\mu}^{(\text{can})} J^{\mu}, \quad (7.2)$$

defining an effective charge $e_{\text{eff}} = e/\sqrt{I}$. The effective fine-structure constant is therefore

$$\alpha_{\text{eff}}(\tau) = \frac{e_{\text{eff}}^2}{4\pi} = \frac{e^2}{4\pi I(\phi)} = \frac{\alpha_0}{I(\phi(\tau))}. \quad (7.3)$$

7.2 Oscillation of α

With $I = e^{2\beta\phi/M}$ and $\phi = \Phi \cos(mt)$:

$$\alpha_{\text{eff}}(t) = \alpha_0 e^{-2\gamma \cos(mt)}. \quad (7.4)$$

For $\gamma \ll 1$ (small oscillation amplitude):

$$\alpha_{\text{eff}}(t) \approx \alpha_0 (1 - 2\gamma \cos(mt)), \quad (7.5)$$

giving a fractional oscillation

$$\boxed{\frac{\Delta\alpha}{\alpha_0} \equiv \frac{\alpha_{\text{eff}} - \alpha_0}{\alpha_0} \approx -2\gamma \cos(mt), \quad \left| \frac{\Delta\alpha}{\alpha_0} \right|_{\text{amp}} = 2\gamma.} \quad (7.6)$$

The *same* parameter γ that controls the tachyonic resonance also controls the amplitude of α oscillations, linking magnetogenesis to laboratory tests.

7.3 Observational Constraints on γ

Several independent measurements bound the time variation of α :

Probe	Redshift	Bound	Timescale
Atomic clocks	$z = 0$	$ \dot{\alpha}/\alpha \lesssim 10^{-17} \text{ yr}^{-1}$	years
Oklo reactor	$z \simeq 0.14$	$ \Delta\alpha/\alpha \lesssim 10^{-8}$	Gyr
Quasar absorption	$z \sim 1\text{--}2$	$ \Delta\alpha/\alpha \lesssim 10^{-5}$	Gyr
CMB	$z \simeq 1100$	$ \Delta\alpha/\alpha _{\text{rec}} \lesssim 10^{-3}$	recombination

The most stringent directly applicable bound is from the Oklo natural nuclear reactor:

$$2\gamma \leq 10^{-8} \implies \gamma < 10^{-8}. \quad (7.7)$$

7.4 Lower Bound on γ from Efficiency

The efficiency condition for the resonance requires $k_c > H_{\text{rec}}$ and $k_c > k_{\text{target}}/a_{\text{rec}}$ (so that the generated field can inverse-cascade to the scale of interest). For a target scale of 1 Mpc:

$$k_c = m\sqrt{\gamma} \gtrsim \max\left(H_{\text{rec}}, \frac{k_1}{a_{\text{rec}}}\right) \simeq 10^{-26} \text{ eV}. \quad (7.8)$$

This sets a *lower* bound: $m\sqrt{\gamma} \gtrsim 10^{-26} \text{ eV}$.

7.5 Parameter-Space Window

Combining the upper bound (7.7) with the lower bound (7.8), there is a viable window in the (m, γ) plane. The upper bound on $B_0(1 \text{ Mpc})$ from $\gamma < 10^{-8}$ follows from Eq. (6.15):

$$B_0(1 \text{ Mpc}) < 10^{-6} F^{1/2} \text{ G}. \quad (7.9)$$

Since $F \leq 1$ and $10^{-6} \text{ G} \gg 10^{-17} \text{ G}$, there is ample room to satisfy the observational lower bound while respecting the α -variation constraint.

Key Result: Summary of constraints:

$$\underbrace{m\sqrt{\gamma} \gtrsim 10^{-26} \text{ eV}}_{\text{efficiency / inverse cascade}} \quad \text{and} \quad \underbrace{\gamma < 10^{-8}}_{\text{Oklo / clocks}}.$$

Both can be satisfied simultaneously for ultralight DM masses $m_{20} \lesssim 10^{16}$.

Chapter 8

Comparison, Discussion, and Open Questions

8.1 Scalar vs. Pseudo-Scalar: Summary Table

Property	Scalar (dilaton)	Pseudo-scalar (axion)
Coupling	$I(\phi)F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu}$	$a F_{\mu\nu}\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu}$
Helicity of B	Non-helical	Helical
Resonance edge	$k_c \simeq am\sqrt{\gamma}$	$k_c \simeq a g_{a\gamma\gamma} m a_0$
Spectrum slope	$n = 1$	$n = 3/2$
Floquet exponent	Independent of k	$\mu_k \propto k^{1/2}$
Extra signature	Oscillating α	None from α
$B_0(1 \text{ Mpc})$ estimate	$\sim 10^{-8} \text{ G}$ (natural params)	$\sim 10^{-15} \text{ G}$ [12]

8.2 Key Observational Discriminator

The most direct way to distinguish the two scenarios is *helicity*. Future 21 cm observations and CMB circular polarisation measurements may detect the helical component of intergalactic magnetic fields (or its absence), directly pointing to pseudo-scalar vs. scalar dark matter.

An additional discriminator unique to the scalar case is the correlated *oscillation of the fine-structure constant* at frequency $\nu = m/(2\pi)$. If the same DM candidate is responsible for both the magnetic fields and an observed variation of α , the coupling β/M derived from each measurement should be consistent.

8.3 Analogy with Preheating after Inflation

The tachyonic resonance explored here is structurally identical to the *parametric resonance reheating* mechanism first analysed in [13,14]. There, the inflaton oscillates coherently after inflation and pumps energy into matter fields via a Mathieu-type equation. The key

difference is that here the “inflaton” is the DM field oscillating at a much later epoch (near recombination), and the “matter field” is the photon.

8.4 Open Questions and Limitations

The paper (and these notes) leave several important questions open:

1. **Residual plasma.** After recombination, a small residual fraction of free electrons persists. Their conductivity damps the gauge field (adding a term $\sigma A'_k$ to the mode equation), potentially suppressing the instability. The authors acknowledge this is not yet computed.
2. **Back-reaction.** The drain of energy from ϕ into photons depletes the DM oscillation amplitude Φ and hence reduces γ and k_c . The fraction F is treated as a free parameter; a detailed computation of F requires solving the coupled system.
3. **Pre-existing fields.** Any magnetic field present at recombination (from earlier cosmic epochs) is not included.
4. **Inhomogeneous modes.** Only the spatially homogeneous condensate of ϕ is included; spatial perturbations of ϕ could seed additional gauge-field production.
5. **CMB imprints.** For $\gamma \sim 10^{-3}$, the oscillating α during recombination modulates the Thomson cross section and leaves an imprint in the CMB power spectrum. A dedicated Boltzmann calculation is needed.

Chapter 9

Conclusions

We have studied in detail the mechanism by which an oscillating ultralight scalar dark-matter field, coupled to the photon through a gauge-kinetic function $I(\phi) = e^{2\beta\phi/M}$, generates cosmological magnetic fields through a tachyonic instability that activates at recombination.

The chain of logic is:

1. Conformal invariance prevents expansion from amplifying free photons; a time-varying $I(\phi)$ breaks this.
2. Introducing the canonical variable $v_k = \sqrt{I} A_k$ transforms the mode equation into a Schrödinger-like equation $v_k'' + \omega_k^2 v_k = 0$ with time-dependent effective mass.
3. For an oscillating ϕ , the effective mass squared is negative during one half of each oscillation cycle, driving exponential growth of modes $k < k_c \simeq m\sqrt{\gamma}$.
4. The backreaction-limited amplitude at recombination is $B_{\text{rec}}(k_c) \sim F^{1/2} \text{ G}$.
5. Via the non-helical inverse cascade (slope $n = 1$), power is redistributed to large scales, and after redshifting,

$$B_0(1 \text{ Mpc}) \simeq 10^{-8} \beta^{-1/2} m_{20}^{-1/2} \left(\frac{M}{M_{\text{pl}}} \right)^{1/2} F^{1/2} \text{ G}.$$

6. The efficiency condition requires only $\beta \gtrsim 10^{-8}/m_{20}$, extraordinarily mild.
7. Constraints from the time variation of α require $\gamma < 10^{-8}$, compatible with efficient magnetogenesis over a wide parameter space.

The scalar DM scenario is a viable, predictive, and observationally distinctive alternative to inflationary and phase-transition magnetogenesis. Its unique signatures — non-helical field, oscillating fine-structure constant — make it testable with next-generation probes.

Appendix A

Useful Identities and Reference Formulae

A.1 FRW Christoffel Symbols (Conformal Time)

With $g_{\mu\nu} = a^2\eta_{\mu\nu}$, the non-zero Christoffel symbols are

$$\Gamma_{00}^0 = \mathcal{H}, \quad \Gamma_{ij}^0 = \mathcal{H}\delta_{ij}, \quad \Gamma_{0j}^i = \mathcal{H}\delta_j^i, \quad (\text{A.1})$$

where $\mathcal{H} = a'/a$ is the conformal Hubble parameter.

A.2 Field-Strength Tensor Components

$$F_{\mu\nu} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -E_x & -E_y & -E_z \\ E_x & 0 & -B_z & B_y \\ E_y & B_z & 0 & -B_x \\ E_z & -B_y & B_x & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad F_{\mu\nu}F^{\mu\nu} = 2(B^2 - E^2). \quad (\text{A.2})$$

In components: $F_{0i} = -E_i$, $F_{ij} = -\epsilon_{ijk}B_k$.

A.3 Dual Field-Strength Tensor

$$\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu} = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon^{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}F_{\rho\sigma}, \quad F_{\mu\nu}\tilde{F}^{\mu\nu} = -4\mathbf{E} \cdot \mathbf{B}. \quad (\text{A.3})$$

A.4 Conversion Factors

$$1 \text{ G} = 1.95 \times 10^{-2} \text{ eV}^2 = 1.95 \times 10^{-20} \text{ GeV}^2, \quad (\text{A.4})$$

$$1 \text{ eV} = 1.16 \times 10^4 \text{ K} \quad (\text{temperature via } k_B T), \quad (\text{A.5})$$

$$M_{\text{pl}} = (8\pi G)^{-1/2} = 2.435 \times 10^{18} \text{ GeV} = 2.435 \times 10^{27} \text{ eV}, \quad (\text{A.6})$$

$$T_{\text{rec}} \simeq 0.26 \text{ eV} \simeq 3000 \text{ K}, \quad (\text{A.7})$$

$$a_{\text{rec}} = 1/1100, \quad H_{\text{rec}} \simeq 10^{-29} \text{ eV}, \quad (\text{A.8})$$

$$k_1 \equiv (1 \text{ Mpc})^{-1} 2\pi \simeq 10^{-29} \text{ eV}. \quad (\text{A.9})$$

A.5 Summary of Key Equations

$$\text{Coupling: } I(\phi) = e^{2\beta\phi/M}, \quad (\text{A.10})$$

$$\text{DM field: } \phi(\tau) = \Phi \cos(m\tau), \quad \Phi \simeq T_{\text{rec}}^2/m, \quad (\text{A.11})$$

$$\text{Parameter: } \gamma = \beta\Phi/M \simeq \beta T_{\text{rec}}^2/(mM), \quad (\text{A.12})$$

$$\text{Critical scale: } k_c \simeq m\sqrt{\gamma}, \quad (\text{A.13})$$

$$\text{Efficiency: } \beta > T_{\text{rec}}^2 M/(mM_{\text{pl}}^2), \quad (\text{A.14})$$

$$\text{Mag. field today: } B_0(1 \text{ Mpc}) \simeq 10^{-8} \beta^{-1/2} m_{20}^{-1/2} (M/M_{\text{pl}})^{1/2} F^{1/2} \text{ G}, \quad (\text{A.15})$$

$$\text{Fine structure: } |\Delta\alpha/\alpha|_{\text{amp}} = 2\gamma < 10^{-8}. \quad (\text{A.16})$$

Appendix B

Power Spectrum Conventions

The *power spectrum* $P_f(k)$ of a field $f(\mathbf{x})$ is defined by

$$\langle f(\mathbf{k}) f^*(\mathbf{k}') \rangle = (2\pi)^3 \delta^{(3)}(\mathbf{k} - \mathbf{k}') P_f(k). \quad (\text{B.1})$$

The variance is

$$\langle f^2 \rangle = \int \frac{d^3k}{(2\pi)^3} P_f(k) = \int_0^\infty \frac{k^3 P_f(k)}{2\pi^2} \frac{dk}{k} = \int_0^\infty \Delta_f^2(k) d \ln k. \quad (\text{B.2})$$

The *dimensionless* (log-interval) power spectrum is $\Delta_f^2(k) = k^3 P_f(k)/(2\pi^2)$.

The power spectrum is the Fourier transform of the two-point correlation function:

$$\xi_f(r) = \langle f(\mathbf{x}) f(\mathbf{x} + \mathbf{r}) \rangle = \int \frac{d^3k}{(2\pi)^3} P_f(k) e^{i\mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{r}}. \quad (\text{B.3})$$

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